Introduction

A Tableau dashboard is a consolidated view of multiple worksheets and associated data in one central location. It is used to compare and monitor a variety of data simultaneously. The different data views are displayed all at once.
A well-designed dashboard provides quick access to relevant and actionable information. It facilitates stakeholders' comprehension, analysis, and presentation of important insights while optimizing the visual representation of complex data.

To achieve an effective and user-friendly dashboard, consider the following best practices:

Purpose

The most effective visualizations have an obvious and distinct purpose and are most suited to their target viewers. Know the goal and the purpose beforehand so that you design the dashboard in alignment with that purpose. A good dashboard communicates the purpose or business goal.

Preparation

Well-defined objectives guide your design and data selection for creating the dashboard. Before designing the dashboard, ask yourself the following questions: What message do you want to convey through your dashboard? What details are needed, and who will be utilizing it? Spend some time analyzing the dashboard's flow and finalizing the visual hierarchy.

Visualization

Different charts excel at expressing different sorts of information. Choose a chart type based on the facts and the message you wish to convey. Inappropriate charts or graphs may not effectively convey the underlying data. You should carefully consider labels and legends, including font, size, and color, to ensure they don't obscure the chart but are large enough for easy reading.

Maintain consistency in design elements such as colors, fonts, and icons to create a cohesive and professional appearance. Inconsistency in design elements can create a disjointed and unprofessional appearance. Prioritizing the rounding of numbers is crucial to avoid overwhelming the audience with numerous decimal places. A good dashboard presents relevant information without clutter. Focus on critical key performance indicators (KPIs), essential information, and effective communication of key insights.

Layout

Follow the inverted pyramid concept from journalism. It divides a news report into three parts: important information at the top, significant details for an overview, and general background information at the bottom. Display the most significant information on the top part of the dashboard, trends in the center, and detailed information at the bottom. Include two or three layout styles in your dashboards to present them for the devices the stakeholders will most likely use to view them. By creating a different layout for each of the various device-types, you provide an optimum experience for your users when viewing your dashboard from their varying devices. Leverage the features to allow users to filter data and drill down into details. Dashboards will be challenging to read if there is an imbalance in the white space. Use white space effectively to separate sections and guide the user's eye. You may also include borders to separate the different views.

Test

Testing a dashboard before you present it to stakeholders is essential, too. It will help you identify errors, ensure data accuracy, evaluate user experience, validate visualizations, conduct functional testing, assess performance, ensure security checks, gather user feedback, ensure compliance with industry standards, and build confidence.

Dashboard design should balance functionality, aesthetics, and user-centricity to provide valuable insights and an efficient user experience. Obtaining regular user feedback and staying updated with evolving data needs will help ensure your dashboards remain relevant and impactful.

Further Reading

For more information on best practices for dashboard design, refer to the *Best Practices for Effective Dashboards* article from Tableau.

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